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Some Remarks on the *Super Esaiam* of Pseudo-Joachim of Fiore

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Some time ago, while browsing medieval collections in the Wrocław University Library, I came across a thirteenth-century Latin manuscript which contained several intriguing images. Among them, there were some simple diagrams consisting of geometric shapes (circles and squares), as well as decorative illustrations of instruments (trumpet, psaltery) and dragons. All of them were accompanied by numerous captions and marginal glosses. It turned out that the manuscript (signature: Mil. II 8 membr.) originally belonged to Johann Gottlieb Milich's Library in Görlitz and was relocated after the Second World War.¹ It is divided into two parts: the first one contains a collection of figures presenting the doctrine of Joachim of Fiore (so called *Praemissiones*); the other one is a composite work including commentary on some chapters of Isaiah (*Super Esaiam* or *Super Prophetas*), previously attributed to Joachim of Fiore (†1202), but now recognized as written by one of his followers in the mid-thirteenth century. This unexpected encounter aroused my interest and I decided to learn more about the works included in the manuscript.

The *Praemissiones*, extant in various manuscripts,² are composed of eight to eleven various figures with marginal glosses and short descriptions. Researchers dealing with the legacy of the Calabrian abbot consider it to be a post-Joachimian collection prepared on the basis of genuine figures from the *Liber Figurarum*.³ Both figure collections and their relationship have been thoroughly

- 1 For more information about Milich's collection, see: Robert Joachim, *Geschichte der Milich'schen Bibliothek und ihre Sammlungen*, Thl. I–II, (Görlitz: Jungandreas, 1876–1877).
- 2 The list of manuscripts including *Praemissiones* and *Super Esaiam* can be found in: David Morris, "A Census of Known 'Super Prophetas' Manuscripts", *Oliviana* [Online] 4 (2012). Accessed March 15, 2014. <http://oliviana.revues.org/530>.
- 3 *Liber Figurarum* is a collection of diagrams illustrating the original views of Joachim of Fiore. For a long time, it was considered to be lost, but then was discovered (independently) in manuscripts from Reggio Emilia (published in 1939) and Oxford (published in 1942). The edition based on all known manuscripts was prepared in 1953 by Leone Tondelli, Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, (eds.), "*Liber*

examined by Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch Reich⁴ (who, however, were convinced that the Milich's manuscript was lost).

The *Super Esaïam*, which also includes its own figures, has not yet drawn much attention of scholars.⁵ In manuscripts, it is usually preceded by the *Praemissiones* and in such combination the two texts were published in Venice in 1517.⁶ After having studied that edition (I will refer to it throughout this whole article), I decided to share my reflections on the text, especially on the comments on Isaiah. I will begin with a short overview of two issues concerning the *Super Esaïam*, namely the text's origin and content. The first point was recently discussed by David Morris who collected and compared all existing studies on the *Super Esaïam*.⁷ According to him, it is impossible to determine whether the work comes from the Cistercian or the Franciscan milieu, since the teachings of Joachim of Fiore spread in both communities in southern Italy. As for the dating, Morris argues for 1260s as the most probable time.

In terms of content, one can distinguish three main parts of the *Super Esaïam*. The first one begins with a short prologue addressed to Joachim's companion, Rainer of Ponza (fol. 1r), which is followed by a commentary on chapters 1–9 and 11 of Isaiah (fols. 1r–9r). As for the format, the commentary is a freestanding lemmatic one: the biblical text is not quoted in its entirety, but single words or short extracts (*lemmata*) are cited. They are provided with explanations containing many references to various chapters of Isaiah and the other books of the Bible. There are also numerous marginal glosses with further explanations and biblical references. It is significant that only selected verses of each chapter of Isaiah are analyzed; for instance, in the first chapter, sixteen verses out of thirty-one are explicated, and in the fifth one, only six out of thirty. The author himself writes about these omissions and justifies them, stating that his intention was to shed light on what was obscure, and leave out what was

Figurarum". Il libro delle Figure dell'abate Gioacchino da Fiore, (Torino: Società editrice internazionale, 1953). The individual figures from this collection are described in detail in: Marjorie Reeves, Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The "Figurae" of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972).

4 Marjorie Reeves, Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, "The 'Figurae' of Joachim of Fiore. Genuine and Spurious Collections." *Mediaeval and Renaissance Studies* 3 (1954), 170–199.

5 Ibid., 285–288; David Morris, "The Historiography of the 'Super Prophetas' (also known as 'Super Esaïam') of Pseudo-Joachim of Fiore", *Oliviana* [Online], 4 (2012). Accessed March 15, 2014. <http://oliviana.revues.org/512>.

6 Pseudo-Joachimus Florentis, *Scriptum super Esaïam Prophetam* (Venetiis: Lazaro de Sordis, 1517).

7 See: Morris, "The Historiography..." , 25–34.

lucid.⁸ All the comments are primarily of a typological character, i.e. the author attempts to present prefigurations of the New Testament events in the text of Isaiah. For example, seven women, who are taking hold of one man in Isa. 4:1 provide a parallel to seven gifts of the Holy Spirit in Acts 2:1–13.⁹

The second part, entitled *De oneribus sexti temporis*, describes the tribulation which will be sent by God upon the mankind during the sixth *tempus*. It may be useful here to summarize briefly the view of the Calabrian abbot on stages in the world's history. Joachim believed that there are two different, but complementary, historical patterns: *prima diffinitio* and *secunda diffinitio*.¹⁰ The first one refers to the Holy Trinity: there are three ages (*status*) that correspond to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. There are also three orders, related to each *status* respectively: the married laity (*ordo coniugatorum*), the clergy (*ordo clericorum*), and the monks (*ordo monachorum*). The age of the Father encompassed the period from Adam until the birth of Jesus; the age of the Son lasted up until the time of Joachim; the final one, the age of the Holy Spirit, which has yet to come, will lead the believers to the summit of the spiritual life. It is significant that the last *status* will take place on the earth, before the end of the world. These ages, however, are not sharply separated, but overlap to some extent. For instance, some signs of the second *status* appeared already in the first one, and so forth.¹¹

The second pattern, *secunda diffinitio*, is based upon the seven days of creation. This idea was not new, since already Saint Augustine proposed it in the *De Civitate Dei*¹², but Joachim developed it. According to him, there are two *tempora*, each divided into seven *etates*. The first *tempus* corresponds to the first *status*, and the second *tempus* to the second *status* (except for the seventh *etas* of the second *tempus* – the sabbath, which is identified with the third *status*, the age

8 *Super Esaiam* (Wrocław University Library MS Mil. II 8, fol. 8r): “In premissis capitulis plura dimisimus, sicut et in locis aliis, quia patent. Sufficit enim si illa solummodo illucescere facimus que obscurioribus sunt sensibus involuta.”

9 Ibid., fol. 4v: “‘Apprehenderunt septem mulieres virum unum in die illa’ [Isa. 4:1]. Nonnulli putant septem mulieres totidem donationes spiritus designare [...].”

10 These patterns can be seen on the figures: the *Seven Etates* and the *Trinitarian Circles* of the *Liber Figurarum*, see: Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The “Figurae”*..., 120–129, 192–198.

11 These patterns are much more complicated, for details, see E. Randolph Daniel, “The Double Procession of the Holy Spirit in Joachim of Fiore’s Understanding of History,” *Speculum* 55, 3 (1980): 469–483; idem, “Joachim’s Unnoticed Pattern of History: The Second Diffinitio,” in *Joachim of Fiore and the Influence of Inspiration: Essays in Memory of Marjorie E. Reeves (1905–2003)*, ed. by J. E. Wannenmacher (Farnham: Ashgate, 2013), 3–13.

12 Aug. *Civ. Dei* 11.8. See Paul Archambault, “The Ages of Man and the Ages of the World. A Study of two Traditions,” *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 12 (1966): 200–206.

of the Holy Spirit). One of the most crucial elements of Joachim's doctrine is the assumption that the events from the Old Testament have their counterparts in the New Testament and also in the events which will come in the future. Consequently, it is possible to deduce the future by interpreting the Old Testament.¹³ The seven *etates* of the first *tempus* in the *secunda diffinitio* are parallel to the seven *etates* in the second one. Since Joachim claimed to be living in the fifth *etas*, one would expect events similar to those described in the Old Testament to happen. Each *etas* (in both *tempora*) was also associated with the opening of one of the seven seals. Furthermore, in every *etas* there is a king who inflicts persecution on the believers.¹⁴ The four kings of the second *tempus* were: Herod, Nero, Constantius the Arian (Constantius II), and Chosroes (Khosrau II, King of the Persians who invaded the Byzantine Empire) – each *etas* experienced an inevitable tribulation. *Liber de Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, one of Joachim's essential works, is entirely devoted to this problem.¹⁵

The text particularly appreciated by the Calabrian abbot as a source for the motifs and symbolic numbers was the Apocalypse. According to his own testimony, he experienced enlightenment while working on the commentary on the Book of Revelation, which led to his understanding of the relation between the two Testaments.¹⁶ Take the *secunda diffinitio* as an example: the openings of the seals refer to the book with seven seals in Apoc. 6–8, whereas the seven kings represent the seven heads of the Apocalyptic Dragon in Apoc. 12–13.¹⁷

Let us come back to the *Super Esaiam*. The part *De oneribus sexti temporis* describes the persecution in the sixth *etas* of the second *tempus* (using the original Joachim's terminology), which is yet to come. In order to predict the future, the author chose the Old Testament's *onera*, 'the burdens', as parallels. According to Isaiah and three minor prophets, they were to be sent upon various

13 Also the author of the *Super Esaiam* expresses this belief: "Videsne, lector, quomodo sunt involuta mysteria scripturarum, ubi per ea, que facta sunt, futura alia prenoscuntur?" (*Super Esaiam*, fol. 31r)

14 This idea is also presented in the *Super Esaiam*, fol. 50v: "Synagoge per septem libri signacula et tempora pressurarum; fluvius vero Novum Testamentum est continens septem apertiones sigillorum que facte sunt per totidem draconis capita in ecclesia militanti."

15 Abbot Joachim of Fiore, *Liber de Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, ed. E. R. Daniel, Transactions of the American Philosophical Society, vol. 73, 8 (Philadelphia, 1983).

16 The *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, published in Venice in 1527, is one of the key works of Joachim of Fiore.

17 There is a figure of the Dragon with Seven Heads both in the *Liber Figurarum* and in the *Praemissiones*, see: Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The "Figurae" of Joachim of Fiore*, 146–152.

tribes and regions as a punishment for their sins. In the *Super Esaïam*, the ‘burdens’ consisted primarily of invasions and persecutions by heretics and pagans.

The section under discussion begins with a figure of concentric circles on fol. 9v. In the middle of it, there is a caption: *Visio super Hierusalem* (‘vision of Jerusalem’), which is surrounded by another caption: “Hierusalem in medio gentium posita est sicut onus lapidis.” This is, arguably, a reference to Zech. 12:3:

“Et erit: In die illa ponam Ierusalem lapidem oneris cunctis populis: omnes, qui levabunt eam, concisione lacerabuntur; et colligentur adversus eam omnia regna terrae”.¹⁸

The outermost circle contains fourteen *onera* – eleven from Isaiah and three from minor prophets (Nahum, Habakkuk, Malachi). This figure has a short explanation indicating regions or people to whom particular *onera* refer.¹⁹ Next, there is a brief introduction (fol. 10r–v), followed by seventeen folios of simple geographic diagrams (fols. 11r–27v), presenting probably all the places of the world known to the author of the *Super Esaïam*. They are provided with numerous marginal glosses, mainly with the Bible references. Their role is to illustrate all the regions that are to be affected by the *onera*. At the end of this “geographic” section, a justification of such a great punishment is presented: since all people together distanced themselves from God (*communis excessus omnium*), the affliction would spread over the entire world (*universalis transitus*

18 “And it shall come to pass in that day, that I will make Jerusalem a burdensome stone to all people: all that shall lift it up shall be rent and torn, and all the kingdoms of the earth shall be gathered together against her.” (Zech. 12:3)

19 *Super Esaïam*, fols. 9v–10r: “Onus verbi Domini [Mal. 1:1], quod replicat Malachias ultimus prophetarum, tangit Iudeos et populum gentium seculi lubricum et tripudium salvandorum. Onus Babylonis [Isa. 13:1] secundum concordiam tangit Romam sicut Caldea Alemaniam Onus Philistiim [Isa. 11:14]: secundum concordiam Lombardos et alios Italos et Guilelmandalos. Onus Moab [Isa. 15:1] et filiorum Amon [Isa. 11:14]: principes Latinos et Grecos. Onus deserti maris [Isa. 21:1]: Affricanos et alios Saracenos. Onus Duma [Isa. 21:11] vel Idumee tangit Iudeos negociatores. Onus maris [in the Venetian edition “os mare”] et terre [Isa. 24:15–16]: sapientes et legistas et Grecos. Onus in Arabia [Isa. 21:13] Hyspanos et Marchianos. Onus vallis visionis [Isa. 22:1]: cuiuscunque ordinis regulares. Onus Tyri [Isa. 23:1]: Siculos et regnicolas sibi subiacentes. Onus Egypti [Isa. 19:1]: Iudeos, Danaos et Francos. Onus iumentorum austri [Isa. 30:6]: clericos, prelatos, rectores eorum ubique diffusos. Onus Damasci [Isa. 17:1] tangit Thucos et Ligures in gladio verbi Domini et ferro effundendos et conterendos. Onus Ninive [Nah. 1:1] tangit mundum pollutum sanguine peccatorum: ecclesiam tam in Greco populo quam Latino; Assyricos atterendum exterminium. Onus Abacuch [Hab. 1:1] tangit peccatores seculi, transgressores legis et fidei, Iudeos, Italicos, adventum Christi in carne, crucis patibulum, vocationem paganorum.”

flagellorum).²⁰ Nevertheless, after these hardships the sabbath, the time of peace and rest (*pacis et otii sabbatismus*) will come to chosen places.²¹ The section that follows contains descriptions of individual *onera* (fols. 28r–49v). Their order, however, differs from the one presented in the figure of concentric circles, which I find difficult to explain.

The third and last part also has its own title: *De septem temporibus ecclesie* (fols. 49v–59v); it refers to the *secunda diffinitio* and seven *etates* of the second *tempus*. David Morris, in the article mentioned above, suggests that this part is “a separate tract”.²² One should, however, pay particular attention to its opening, in which we read: “Ecce ab oneribus omnibus expediti...” (*Super Esaiam*, fol. 49v) – “Here, having freed ourselves from all burdens...” These words might indicate a connection with the previous part. The beginning continues: “[...] quibus orbis in suis urbibus eque pro peccatis affligitur, ut facilius corrigatur [...]” (*Super Esaiam*, fol. 49v), “with which the world in its cities is everywhere equally oppressed for its sins, in order that it may be easier corrected [...]”. This might refer to the world represented in the above-mentioned geographic diagrams. This part also includes a figure (fol. 50v): it depicts the Old Testament Tabernacle with two captions in the middle (one above the other): “Longos fac funiculos tuos et clavos tuos consolida” (in the Venetian edition, we find twice “tres” instead of “tuos” and “curvos” instead of “clavos”; evidently in the manuscript the sentence accompanying the drawing had been written with smaller letters, and the printer had troubles reading it) and “forma tabernaculi federis” (a figure of the Tabernacle of the Covenant). The first one is a paraphrase of Isa. 54:2:

“Dilata locum tentorii tui, et pelles tabernaculorum tuorum extende, ne parcas;
longos fac funiculos tuos, et clavos tuos consolida.”²³

Below these captions, there is another one: “Sacra pagina” – the Bible. Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich argue that the Holy Scripture is symbolized by the fundament on which the Tabernacle is based²⁴, whereas in my opinion the Bible, as an object of great value and importance, is rather stored in the

20 Ibid., fol. 27v: “Non ambigimus omnes seculi per circuitum regiones propter malitiam sexti temporis et etatis a gentibus infidelibus feriendas; et iccirco quia communis excessus est omnium, universalis erit et transitus flagellorum.”

21 Ibid., fol. 27v: “Post exterminium harum omnium regionum succedet electis reliquiis pacis et otii sabbatismus.”

22 See Morris, “The Historiography...”, 3.

23 “Enlarge the place of thy tent, and stretch out the skins of thy tabernacles, spare not: lengthen thy cords, and strengthen thy stakes.” (Isa. 54:2)

24 See Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The “Figurae” of Joachim of Fiore*, 287.

Tabernacle, which plays similar function as the Ark of the Covenant. Besides, the Old Testament Tabernacle served as a place of encounter with God and reading of the Bible is such an encounter to some extent. The four sides of the figure are indicated by the four directions of the world, which represent the four senses of Scripture.²⁵ However, they were not exactly the same as those transmitted by the patristic tradition, because the Calabrian abbot invented his own sophisticated “system” of biblical exegesis.²⁶ In his teachings, he distinguishes four main senses (*intellectus*): typological (with seven sub-categories), historical, moral, and allegorical (with three subdivisions). Altogether, they are twelve in number, and in the *Super Esaïam* they are compared to twelve different characters from the Old Testament, whose task, within the context of this figure, is to guard the Tabernacle.²⁷ Their names are also enumerated around the figure.

The rest of the third part of the *Super Esaïam* deals with the seven *etates* of the second *tempus*, which are called “the seven *tempora* of the church” (*septem tempora ecclesie*) here. Although all seven are introduced, only six of them are discussed. The reason might be that during the sixth *etas* the climax of tribulation was to take place and this was the main topic of the whole work. In this part, number seven is used in other contexts as well. The author mentions seven ‘sub-senses’ of the typological sense of Scripture, seven synagogues and, significantly, seven streams (*septem rivi*) from Isa. 11:15:

“Et desolabit Dominus linguam maris Aegypti, et levabit manum suam super flumen in fortitudine spiritus sui; et percutiet eum in septem rivis, ita ut transeant per eum calceati.”²⁸

25 *Super Esaïam*, fol. 50r: “Et in evangelio Joannis: ‘Ego sum ostium, per me si quis intraverit, salvabitur et ingredietur et pascua inveniet’ [John 10:9], scilicet spiritualium lectionum. Habet enim volumen divine pagine quadruplicem intellectum: moralem ab oriente, hystoricum ab occidente, typicum ab aquilone, allegoricum ab austro, et ascensiones notate sunt successive.” The creator of this figure might have been inspired by the *Rotae of Ezekiel* from the *Liber Figurarum*, see: Reeves, Hirsch-Reich, *The “Figurae” of Joachim of Fiore*, 224–231.

26 See Herbert Grundmann, *Studien über Joachim von Fiore. Mit einem Vorwort zum Neudruck. (Unveränderter reprographischer Nachdruck der Ausgabe Leipzig 1927)* (Stuttgart: Teubner, 1966), 18–55; Henri de Lubac, *Exégèse médiévale: les quatre sens de l’Écriture*, I, 2 (Paris: Aubier, 1961), 437–558.

27 Ibid., fol. 50r: “Sic ad custodiam tabernaculi federis in plagis suis viri duodecim deputantur ad instar totidem intellectuum...”

28 “And the Lord shall lay waste the tongue of the sea of Egypt, and shall lift up his hand over the river in the strength of his spirit: and he shall strike it in the seven streams, so that men may pass through it in their shoes.” (Isa. 11:15)

This division of the river into seven streams symbolizes the division of the God's revelation into seven parts (*particule*), so that each part could be revealed during each of the seven *tempora ecclesie* (or *etates*).

It should be added that the Venetian editors made a mistake while dividing the text into sections. Their edition consists of seven parts, although there should be only three: the commentary on Isaiah, *De oneribus sexti temporis* and *De septem temporibus ecclesie*. The reason is that the third one was incorrectly split into five parts, which were entitled *secunda pars libri*, *tertia pars libri* and so on, up to *sexta pars libri*. *De oneribus sexti temporis* is called *prima pars* in the Venetian edition, while the first part of the whole text – the commentary on Isaiah – has no number. However, the expression *tertia pars libri* (“the third part of the book”) does not refer to the part of work as a whole, but only to the opening of the third seal of the apocalyptic book which is described there; it is indicated by the fact, that the openings of the first and second seals are mentioned right above.²⁹ Similarly for the *quarta pars libri* and so on.

Turning to the role of Isaiah in the text, I assume that the author, as a follower of Joachim of Fiore, wished to propagate the teachings of his master and that this was his main goal in all three parts of the *Super Esaiam*. In my opinion, he wanted to explicate the sense of history to his contemporaries, so that they were prepared for the imminent persecutions and aware that after the great suffering, the age of the Holy Spirit will eventually come. For a supporter of Joachim's, the most proper way to present such matters was to refer to the harmony of the two Testaments. So, assuming that all present and future events have their prefigurations in the Old Testament, he had to find an adequate passage, one containing warnings and threats of future tribulation. For this purpose, the Book of Isaiah was, indeed, a right choice, since it includes a great deal of oracles against Judah and other nations. In general, its themes are the wrath of God, the judgment over Israel, and the punishment for its perfidiousness – but also hope for the future time of peace, which was to emanate from the New Jerusalem. As one can see, all these prophecies may be useful while referring to the teachings of Joachim of Fiore, especially in the context of the sixth *etas* and the age of the Holy Spirit. In my opinion the chapters of Isaiah that are included in the commentary might have been chosen intentionally. They all concern persecutions and the final liberation of the God's

29 *Super Esaiam*, fol. 51r: “Igitur sub apertione primi signaculi vel sigilli ordo apostolicus in albo equo designatus exivit: qui ad regnandas animas errore pollutas datus est arcus celestis eloquij et irrefragabilis corona triumphii. [...] In secunda parte libri soluto secundo signaculo sub secundo draconis capite seviente interfecti sunt Christi martyres a paganis: sicut antiqua Madianitarum Philistiimque prelia protestantur.”

chosen nation, and therefore may be seen as relevant for the situation of the Roman Church in the time between the sixth and seventh *etas*. Therefore, the first part of the *Super Esaiam* is closely related to the second one, *De oneribus sexti temporis*, which also describes the imminent affliction and also draws much from Isaiah. Unlike these two, the third one is based rather on the Apocalypse, although there is one remarkable reference to a passage from the Isaiah – the one concerning the seven streams (Isa. 11:15), which was already discussed. Nevertheless this part has a similar goal – it continues to present the sense of history according to views of Joachim of Fiore.

On the whole, I think that the *Super Esaiam* is an interesting example of various methods being used to demonstrate and explain certain elaborate views. The first one is the biblical exegesis. Considering the first part of the *Super Esaiam*, we may suppose that the author's final intention was not just to comment on Isaiah, but rather to use the commentary form as a means to an end. The second part consists of the marginal glosses. They occur throughout the entire work and, since they are a special feature of ancient and medieval commentaries, they serve as an aid to present all the unclear words and expressions. Finally, there are figures, the most original aspect of abbot's of Fiore works. The author of the *Super Esaiam* probably came across that reader-friendly way of illustrating complex patterns while he was studying the teachings of his master. That might have encouraged him to provide the text with his own diagrams and thereby enrich one of the secondary sources of Joachim's thought.